

My Most Transformative Moment

Camus wrote at the end of *The Myth of Sisyphus*, "The struggle itself towards the heights is enough to fill a man's heart. One must imagine Sisyphus happy." This profound idea struck a deep chord within me, resolving a long-standing question that stemmed from a transformative mountain-climbing experience.

It was during a summer vacation that my family and I decided to climb Mount Fuji. The intention was to challenge myself, to build resilience against future setbacks. We started from the hillside at midnight. The initial part felt more like a walk than a climb, the path being relatively gentle. However, as we ascended, the altitude began to take its toll. The cold intensified, bringing with it headaches, dizziness, and a suffocating breathlessness – the classic symptoms of altitude sickness.

I shivered, sneezed, and my legs grew heavy as lead. This was a level of hardship I'd rarely encountered, and it chipped away at my resolve. Just as I was on the brink of giving up, someone ahead in the seemingly endless line pointed upwards and shouted, "Look! The mountaintop! It's so close!" I followed his gaze, and there it was, the peak, beckoning me forward. My heart surged with renewed courage and hope. Reaching the summit became my sole focus, and I pushed myself onward, already envisioning the breathtaking sunrise that awaited me.

However, as I drew closer to the "mountaintop," I realized it was a cruel trick of perspective. What had appeared to be the peak was merely a higher point on the slope,

made to seem closer due to the darkness and the angle of the climb. Above it loomed another "mountaintop," and who knew if that was the true summit or yet another illusion. The hope I had clung to crumbled, replaced by a cold sense of despair.

The rest of the journey was a passive trudge, fueled not by my own will but by the relentless flow of climbers around me. Even when I finally reached the actual peak, a lingering sense of failure clung to me.

Years later, I found an answer in Camus's philosophical essay. Sisyphus, condemned to eternally push a boulder up a hill only to have it roll back down, is often seen as a tragic figure. Camus, however, argues that Sisyphus finds meaning in his defiance, in his ceaseless struggle against the absurd.

It dawned on me then what had been missing from my climb – the right attitude towards the process and the outcome. Both Sisyphus and I strove towards a goal, both experienced the illusion of nearing the finish line, only to have it recede. Yet, it was Sisyphus, the one who would never reach his destination, who found happiness.

The difference lay in our approach. I had placed all my hopes on the result, climbing passively. Sisyphus, in contrast, actively rebelled against his fate with every push of the boulder. The meaning, then, is not in the achievement but in the striving.

This realization marked a turning point for me. I know I will face more challenges in life, but thanks to Camus, I am now equipped to meet them head-on. The journey itself is where the true meaning lies.